

look at OpenStack or Linux, all these projects have been enhanced by several developers located in India.

The potential of Indian developers is indeed not as high as the professional programmers in western countries, but this does not mean that India is merely a user of open source. There are enormous projects that are being maintained on Indian soil. Also, the size of the Indian market is bigger than most developed regions.

At TechBlue, we have *Hamara Linux* that is our leading open source project. We spent enormous effort, money and time to launch this Indian Linux distribution. The platform has so far been totally developed and maintained by the community in India.

When you go to our GitHub account, you will find projects like JBox Controller, which include plenty of contributions from Indian developers.

So this is how India is already enabling open source growth, and could soon become the leader in terms of the number of developers and contributions.

Q What are your plans to increase community efforts from India?

We are already sponsoring events and conferences to stimulate community interest in our offerings. Additionally, we are organising meetups around *Hamara Linux* in universities and institutes to engage with more IT students and open source enthusiasts in the Indian market. It is a good way to efficiently shop for skilled talent.

Contribution helps a lot in a company like TechBlue, because when you are contributing to a project, a learned person will participate to help you fulfil your goals. In addition to involving others in your project, community efforts are the key to helping open source companies learn innovative ways to succeed.

In addition to the community engagements through tech conventions, we are also looking around for locations to set up some hacker spaces. We would like to have a Hamara Hacker Space in different locations across India. This would give enthusiasts a space to experience and test the Linux platform.

Q How is *Hamara Linux* different from other Linux distributions?

We looked at small things while developing *Hamara Linux*. First, we considered the styling. The distribution should look decent and be culturally acceptable to Indian users. Second, we looked at language, translation and even the naming of the applications. If you are targeting non-native English speakers, then you have to choose names that are in their native languages.

Our *Hamara Linux* is not a universal operating system. Instead, it has been created specifically for one part of society. This is the reason we need to customise the experience only for our niche. This helps us establish more engagements around our product.

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Having said that, *Hamara Linux* is still a Linux distribution at its core, and is based on the same kernel that you might have seen on many other platforms.

Q Apart from the operating system and other solutions in the open source space, you also offer consultancy. Why is there a need for an open source company to provide consultancy?

We offer consultancy because people do not know how to implement an open source solution but are keen to find a relevant option for their operations. It also helps in maintaining an existing deployment.

Through consultancy, we free businesses from being locked in. We also provide the proper information about what customers need to choose today to gain fruitful results in the future.

Q Despite many consultants operating in the market today, do you think there is still lack of training and awareness in the open source world?

Yes, there is lack of knowledge and skills compared to the demand. The demand keeps on growing, but training and awareness of open source remains at a low level.

If you look at companies like Red Hat and SUSE, they have created massive businesses from open source. But the mentality and usage patterns of the common people are yet to evolve. Very few people know how to contribute for free, and similarly, how to receive help or contributions from the available communities.

However, things are getting better now. Students and enthusiasts are now focusing entirely on open source. IT professionals are also taking the open source way to garner profits.

Q How do you manage recruitments for various open source developments?

We actually try to recruit as many people as possible to enrich our projects with their knowledge. Rather than considering academics, we prefer skills.

Q What are your views on open source as a career option?

Open source is huge as a career option. People with experience in open source are likely to find better jobs than other professionals. If you do not know Linux now and you are a developer, you are harming your career prospects. Most people are getting jobs just because of their skills in working with code.

From a career perspective, job seekers need to specify